Though he wiped the betel leaves clean, he never pinched off the stalk. (So thrifty was he!) If he found a coarse leaf, he would strip the veins off. Which always made us think of the old riddle-chant about betel leaves:

Catch hold of Muthappan, strip off his spine,

Smear him with fresh butter…

He would sniff the broken arecanut. Sniffing was supposed to ward off 'intoxication'. Then he would blow on the nut. To get rid of invisible arecanut worms, that's why. This sniffing and blowing, slow to begin with, would increase in speed, hand moving from nose to mouth, until with great noise, *oomoosh, oomoosh*, it was popped into the mouth —tabak!

To find out how tidy a person is, all one has to do is to look at his lime-paste dabba. Where this was concerned, Maamanaar was unmatched. Even the excess lime-paste on his finger wasn't wiped off unnecessarily on other objects. You could press his lime-paste dabba to your eyes with reverence. His Eveready torch, bought fifteen years ago, was still in use, bright and spanking new, as if bought just now. The one bought by our family at the same time had sprung a leak. Dented, yellowing and pitiable, it looked like a chronic patient about to die.

No one but him could use the chair in his house. The first thing he did as soon as he got up every morning was to wipe it. Had it to be shifted, he himself carried it and put it down carefully, as if placing down gently a mud pot brimming with water.

As soon as he saw me, Maamanaar greeted me, "Welcome, dear nephew! Won't you have some betel?" Then he himself answered, "'If schoolboys start chewing betel, chickens will start butting!"

I conveyed to him what Amma asked me to and returned home.

At an ungodly hour in the night, there was a knock on the door. Everyone at home was fast asleep. I woke up Pedanna.

A few people from a house of **bereavement** stood outside for the chair. Pedanna took them into the street. I too followed. When they finished telling us what they came for, Pedanna replied patiently, "Chair only, no? It's in our Maamanaar's house. Go and ask him, he will give it." After sending them off, we returned home, chuckling noiselessly.

Tossing, Appa asked sleepily, "Who was it?"

"What else—some fellows want our bullocks for threshing."

Pulling the bedsheet tightly over him, Appa turned and went back to sleep.

Now it was raining in Maamanaar's forest!

After many days, when I visited Maamanaar, he was sitting on the floor preparing betel leaves. He greeted me with his usual smile and banter.

"What is this? You're sitting on the floor! Where is the chair?" I searched around. Smearing the lime-paste on the back of the betel leaf, he looked intently at me and smiled. He then said calmly,

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